

Lovest thou me more than these?

John 21:15-17

¹⁵ So when they had dined, Jesus saith to Simon Peter, **Simon, son of Jonas, lovest^{G25} thou me more than these?** He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love^{G5368} thee. He saith unto him, **Feed my lambs.**

¹⁶ He saith to him again the second time, **Simon, son of Jonas, lovest^{G25} thou me?** He saith unto him, Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love^{G5368} thee. He saith unto him, **Feed my sheep.**

¹⁷ He saith unto him the third time, **Simon, son of Jonas, lovest^{G5368} thou me?** Peter was grieved because he said unto him the third time, **Lovest^{G5368} thou me?** And he said unto him, Lord, thou knowest all things; thou knowest that I love^{G5368} thee. Jesus saith unto him, **Feed my sheep.**

In **John 21:15**, the demonstrative pronoun "*these*" (translating the Greek genitive plural demonstrative τοῦτων; masculine/neuter) can grammatically and contextually resolve to several distinct antecedents, some of which can be easily missed. A neuter plural demonstrative pronoun, such as "*these*" (τούτων), can syntactically refer to **any** physical, neuter plural objects present at the scene.

1) These other disciples (comparative affection): "Do you love me more than **these other disciples** love me?"

Prior to the crucifixion, Peter explicitly boasted that even if all the other disciples were offended, he never would be (**Matthew 26:33-35**, **Mark 14:29-31**). Jesus prompts Peter to examine whether his devotion truly surpasses that of his brethren, gently confronting his former self-confidence in light of his threefold denial.

2) These other disciples (object of affection): "Do you love me more than you love **these men?**"

Peter shared deep personal bonds and camaraderie with his fellow apostles. In this reading, Jesus asks whether Peter's ultimate allegiance and love belong to Christ above his natural affection for his closest human companions.

3) These material things / fishing trade (neuter antecedent): "Do you love me more than **these things** (the boats, nets, and your old occupation)?"

Immediately preceding this conversation, Peter had initiated a return to his old livelihood, stating, "*I go a fishing*" (**John 21:3**). Standing on the shore beside the net and the haul of 153 fishes, Jesus asks if Peter loves his old trade, temporal security, and comfort more than his higher commission to serve Him.

4) These "*fish*" (ὀψάρια, neuter plural) and "*bread*" cooked on the coals (**John 21:9,13**).

Historically and exegetically, the comparison to the devotion of the other disciples (Option 1) and the contrast with the fishing equipment and trade (Option 3) remain the two most prominent interpretations of the text. However, the grammar permits all of *these* interpretations *simultaneously*. Commentators often miss the whole picture by using man's wisdom to remove the food from the category of "moral masters" that darkness, money, and/or the praise of men falls into. But, that's not what the word of God does: instead, food, darkness, money, and the praise of men are **all** grouped together because *agapao* G25 by men is applied to all of them.

Elsewhere, Scripture agrees with itself that these are all objects that can govern how we choose, what we do, and who we obey: **Phil 3:19**, **Heb 12:16**, **Rom 1:25**. And that's exactly what Jesus was addressing with Peter: do you love me more than all these people **and** these things?

If we carefully review the Strong's numbers in what Jesus and Peter said, He asked Peter if he loved Him *two different ways*, not one: G25 “*agapao*” (v15,16) and G5368 “*phileo*” (v17).

G25 ἀγαπάω (agapāō | ag-ap-ah'-o)

Examples: Matthew 5:44, 22:37,39 Mark 10:21, 12:30,31, Luke 6:27,35, 7:5, John 3:16,19, 12:43, 14:15

Derivation: perhaps from ἄγαν (much) (or compare G5689)

Strong's: to love (in a social or moral sense)

KJV: (be-)love(-ed). Compare G5368.

See: G5689, G5368

Cognate Group: G27 (beloved), G26 (charity), G25 (love) Variants: ἀγαπάω

Hebrew Equivalents: H157 אָהַב, H157 אָהַב, H935 בָּאָהַב, H2142 זָכַר, H2398 אָהַב, H2654 אָהַב, H3039 אָהַב, H3040 אָהַב, H3173 אָהַב, H4191 מוֹת, H4885 מִשְׁוֹשׁ, H5689 אָהַב, H6213 אָהַב, H6601 אָהַב, H7069 אָהַב, H7355 אָהַב, H7521 אָהַב, H8104 אָהַב, H8173 אָהַב, H8191 אָהַב

G5368 φιλέω (philéō | fil-eh'-o)

Examples: Mat 6:5, 10:37, 23:6, Mar 14:44 (kiss), Luk 20:46, Joh 20:2, 1Co 16:22, Rev 3:19

Derivation: from G5384

Strong's: to be a friend to (fond of (an individual or an object)), i.e. have affection for (denoting personal attachment, as a matter of sentiment or feeling; while G25 is wider, embracing especially the judgment and the deliberate assent of the will as a matter of principle, duty and propriety: the two thus stand related very much as G2309 and G1014, or as G2372 and G3563 respectively; the former being chiefly of the heart and the latter of the head); specially, to kiss (as a mark of tenderness)

KJV: kiss, love.

See: G5384, G2372, G25, G2309, G1014, G3563

Cognate Group: G5387 (kindly affectioned), G5384 (friend), G5377 (lover of God), G5369 (lover of pleasure), G5383 (love to have the preeminence), G2705 (kiss), G5370 (kiss), G5373 (friendship), G5367 (lover of own self), G5368 (kiss) Variants: φιλέω

Hebrew Equivalents: H157 אָהַב, H5401 נָשַׁק, H7453 רָעַ

Commentators that note that Jesus was addressing Peter's “heart” devotion (*agapao*) to Him are correct, no doubt; however, that's not the whole picture that we're given in the context of John 21:15-17. This can more simply be reiterated with the first and great commandment (Mat 22:38):

Mark 12:30

And thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind, and with all thy strength: this is the first commandment.